

How long is the Great Wall of China?

Around 1,080 miles (1,740 km) of the Great Wall stands today, but no one really knows how far it stretched at its longest, 500 years ago. Estimates range from 5,500 miles (8,850 km) to more than 13,000 miles (21,000 km) in total.

Wide walls

The widest parts of the wall were 30 ft (9 m) across. At its narrowest, the wall was just 12 in (30 cm) wide—the length of a ruler.

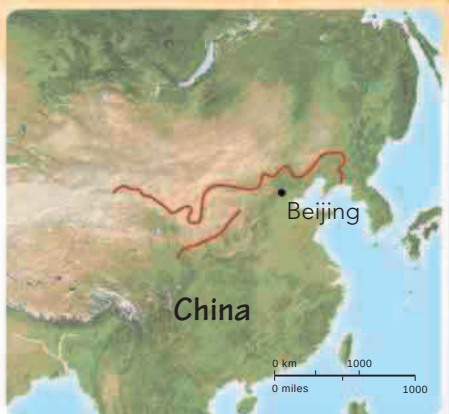
The top of the Great Wall was used as a road.

Signal towers

Signal towers were built along the wall. Messages, such as warnings of invasions, were sent from one tower to another.

Where the wall was

This map shows where the wall was 500 years ago. At first, there were several short walls, which were built 2,800 years ago. They were joined together about 400 years later and were added to over time.



The first walls were built to stop northern tribes from invading farmland.